

The Text of the Dharma of Vajra Absorption

Toh 135 · Derge Kangyur

ར་རྒྱུ་ཏིང་ངེ་འཛན་གཟི་སྒྲིལ་གྱི་གཞི།

Toh 135 in the Kangyur is a sūtra known in Tibetan as Dorjé Ting ngé dzin gyi chö kyi yige, and in Sanskrit as the Vajrasamādhisūtra, commonly rendered in English as the Sūtra of Vajra Absorption or the Scripture of Diamond Concentration. It is a Mahāyāna discourse set on Vulture Peak Mountain, where the Buddha addresses a vast assembly of monks, arhats, bodhisattvas, and noble beings, expounding teachings centered on the nature of vajra-like meditative absorption and the profound principles of the Dharma. The text is structured in named chapters, opening with a formal introductory summary in the style of classical Indian sūtra literature, and its assembly scene — featuring celebrated disciples such as Śāriputra, Maudgalyāyana, and Subhūti alongside prominent bodhisattvas — places it firmly within the tradition of the great Mahāyāna sūtras. As Toh 135 in the Kangyur, it belongs to the general sūtra section of the Tibetan Buddhist canon and has historically attracted commentary across both East Asian and Tibetan Buddhist traditions.

In the Tibetan tongue: The Text of the Dharma of Vajra Absorption. This is the supreme fascicle. The Text of the Dharma of Vajra Absorption, Chapter One: the introductory chapter on the opening summary.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Buddha was on Mount Gṛdhrakūṭa, the royal city's vulture peak, together with a great Saṅgha of monks numbering ten thousand, all of whom had attained the path of the arhat. Among them were Śāriputra, Maudgalyāyana, Subhūti, and others of that kind. Also present were two thousand arhats and great bodhisattvas, among them Vimukti, the bodhisattva King of Mind, the bodhisattva Unattached, and other bodhisattvas of that kind. Also present were eighty thousand noble persons of good family, among them Noble Brahma-conduct, Great Noble Brahma-conduct, Noble Inquirer, and others of that kind. And gathered together with them were gods, yakṣas, gandharvas, asuras, garuḍas, kiṃnaras, great serpent kings, humans and non-humans, and their like — six hundred trillion in number. Surrounded by a great many queens and consorts, he taught the many assembled beings the Dharma of the Great Vehicle: one flavor in name, true suchness, signlessness, unborn, the space of unchanging truth — the ultimate feeling that is beneficial conduct.

Whoever hears this text and thoroughly memorizes it, even so much as a single four-line verse from the first chapter, and holds it by memory — that person shall be said to have entered into the ground of a buddha's wisdom. By practicing skillful means, teaching sentient beings, and training them, such a person is able to become a great spiritual friend of sentient beings.

When the teaching of the Buddha's text was finished, he sat in cross-legged posture and straightaway dwelt in vajra absorption, body and mind utterly still. At that time, from among the great assembly, a monk by the name of Agasta rose from his seat, joined his palms, placed his knees upon the ground, recited the intention of his mind, and spoke the verse of the chapter:

Supreme in great loving-kindness, most venerable,
through the conduct of wisdom, unobstructed —
for the liberation of the vast multitude of sentient beings,
he practices the path by means of one truth.

All conduct is the path of one flavor;
ultimately, the lesser vehicle is not practiced.
All that is taught is one flavor of teaching,
utterly free from everything untrue.

The Buddha abides on the ground of primordial wisdom,
the unchanging space of genuine truth.
All phenomena arise from the world-realm —
there has never been any unfreed, unliberated one to come.

The countless bodhisattvas,
all of them, liberate sentient beings.
For the most part, those who ask broadly and deeply
know the Dharma-characteristic of emptiness and peace.

Know that there: the unchanging, abiding suchness,
the wisdom and skillful means of the truly gone one.
Therefore, those who manifest and uphold the truth
all follow the path as though it were one vehicle.

The seven husks are without flavor —
as an example: one rain, with its moisture,
causes all grasses to grow and flourish,
yet each has its own distinct nature.

That which is filled with the one flavor of Dharma
pervades everywhere throughout.

As an example: filled by that rain in the same way,
all bring forth the sprout of awakening.

Having entered there, hard as vajra, like a stone,
the truly capable one teaches the Dharma,
cutting through remorse and doubt about change.
The one assembly is sealed and all is accomplished.

The Text of the Dharma of Vajra Absorption, Chapter Two: the chapter on the
Dharma of signlessness.

Then the venerable one rose from absorption and spoke these words:

By means of a buddha's primordial wisdom, one enters into the characteristic
of authentic Dharma, because the essential nature is unchanging. All
miraculous powers of skillful means are likewise without characteristic and
without benefit. Understanding the teaching through a single assembly is
difficult to know and difficult to realize.

Seeing and knowing the two vehicles is not a resting place. Only buddhas and
bodhisattvas are capable of knowing it. To those sentient beings who are fit to
be liberated, the single taste is taught.

At that moment, the bodhisattva Liberation rose from his seat, joined his
palms, and knelt down, making this petition to the Blessed One: Venerable
one, since the buddhas pass away and are gone, the straight Dharma passes
beyond the world. The Dharma of form is practiced within the world. In the
time of the final age, the sentient beings of the five corruptions, through their
many evil deeds, are turned like a wheel through the three realms. When the
time of arising is no more, out of loving compassion for later sentient beings
the buddhas teach the single taste of the unchanging and authentic Dharma of
truth. I pray that those sentient beings and all the others may accordingly be
liberated and freed.

The Blessed One declared: Good man, you are skilled in this — the cause of
arising from the world — and in teaching it to sentient beings. That those
sentient beings thereby obtain the fruit of having arisen from the world is one
great purpose, inconceivable. I have practiced great loving-kindness and great
compassion; had I not taught this, it would have fallen into the domain of
miserliness and grasping. Listen carefully: I will explain and expound this to

you and the others, examining it as a single mind.

Good man, when one teaches and trains sentient beings, there arises no mind of teaching nor any mind of not teaching. That is called the great teaching. It is this: all sentient beings are separated from my mind. All my mind has, from the very beginning, been empty and unmoved. Having obtained the empty mind, there is no illusory emanation of mind. There is no illusion. There is no emanation. When there is neither, one originally obtains birthlessness. The mind of birthlessness abides without emanation.

The bodhisattva Liberation then asked the Blessed One: Venerable one, the essential nature of the minds of sentient beings is empty and unmoved from the very beginning. Yet when the mind that is empty and unmoved still has forms and characteristics appearing to it, how must one practice and train so that the ultimately empty mind may be obtained? I ask the Blessed One to explain and expound this to me out of loving compassion.

The Blessed One declared: Bodhisattva, all characteristics of mind have, from the very beginning, been without a beginning. From the very beginning there is no abode of beginning; they are empty and unmoved, and there is no birth. When there is no birth in mind, one has originally entered into empty unmoving. By means of the mind that is empty and unmoving, one straightaway obtains the empty mind. Good man, in a mind without characteristics there is no mind either, and no self. All characteristics of phenomena are likewise the same.

The bodhisattva Liberation asked the Blessed One: Venerable one, through the practice of whatever Dharma there is — the existence of a self and the existence of mind — all sentient beings experience this, and bondage arises from it. How shall they be freed from it?

The Blessed One declared: Good man, if the existence of a self is constantly placed into the twelve links of cause and condition, the twelve links of cause and condition arose in the first place from cause and effect. The movement of cause and effect arises from the activity of mind. If even mind does not exist, how much less need one speak of the body? If a self exists, then the existence of seeing must also be stilled. If a self does not exist, then the non-existence of seeing must also be stilled. When mind arises, the peaceful nature must also be stilled. When mind is stilled, the nature of arising must also be stilled. When the nature of seeing is stilled, one originally enters into the authentic basic space. Why is this? Because from the very beginning, arising has not been

stilled. When it is neither stilled nor arisen, it neither arises nor is stilled — and all phenomena are likewise the same.

The bodhisattva Groltar then asked the Buddha: "Venerable One, when one sees karmic phenomena arising in sentient beings, how is that seeing to be stilled?"

The Buddha declared: "Venerable bodhisattva, the very seeing of karmic phenomena arising in sentient beings must also be stilled. The very seeing that phenomena are to be stilled must also be stilled. When seeing is stilled, one attains the authentic Dharma of non-existence, and having entered into the essential nature of unchangingness, there is no arising within the unchanging."

The bodhisattva Groltar again asked the Buddha: "Venerable One, if those sentient beings have been established in the non-arising of birth, is that their non-arising of birth?"

The Buddha declared: "The very abiding in non-arising is not birth. Why is this? When there is neither abiding nor birth, that is primordial non-arising. The bodhisattva, by practicing birth together with non-arising, removes the mind of birth. When birth and stilling are simultaneously removed, the later arising of my birth does not arise, and mind is primordially empty and unmoved. When mind is empty and unmoved and there is no attachment, there is no attachment to mind — and that is primordial non-arising."

The bodhisattva Groltar again asked the Buddha: "Venerable One, if there is no attachment to mind, what training and cultivation is there? And further, what training is there?"

The Buddha declared: "The bodhisattva's mind arises from the mind of non-arising, and there is no mind that enters — the later arising is the treasury of the Tathāgata. Since the essential nature is empty and unmoved, it is neither that training exists nor that training does not exist. When training exists, training does not exist, and even the non-existence does not exist — that is the training that is also without training. That which is not even the absence of training is what is called training by name."

The bodhisattva Groltar asked the Buddha: "Venerable One, how then is the essential nature of the treasury of the Tathāgata said to be empty and unmoved?"

The Buddha declared: "The treasury of the Tathāgata is the treasury of the mind of wakefulness and stillness. Its essential nature is emptiness — it is unmoved. If the characteristic marks are to be known, they become entangled in conventional frameworks and are not manifest. The treasury of the Tathāgata is empty in essential nature — it is unmoved."

The bodhisattva Groltar asked the Buddha: "Venerable One, how then is it suitable for the mind of wakefulness and stillness to know the characteristic marks?"

The Buddha declared: "For the bodhisattva, in that conventional framework there is neither what is suitable nor what is unsuitable. Even granting that suitable and unsuitable exist, all minds having arisen and being empty, the intention of the seat stirs — and that is the form of wakefulness and stillness. When the bodhisattva examines the characteristic marks of the essential nature of the later arising, the conventional framework itself becomes vast. Even if one conceives of emptiness and reflects upon a myriad of things, this is of no benefit to the conventional ground of the path; through stirring and disturbance, the sovereign of the later arising of mind is lost. When there is no thinking and no reflection, wakefulness and stillness do not arise, and in accordance with the authentic, there is no movement. When the various consciousnesses are at ease and empty, there is no arising of flowing and wandering, and one attains the five pure phenomena. This is the Great Vehicle. When the bodhisattva enters into the five pure phenomena of a bodhisattva, there is nothing false in mind. When there is nothing false, one originally arrives at the ground of the noble primordial wisdom that is the Tathāgata's own inner knowing. Upon arriving at the ground of primordial wisdom, one must skillfully recognize that all things do not arise from the later moment. When one recognizes that there is no arising from the later moment, then primordially there is no mind of falseness."

The bodhisattva Groltar asked the Buddha: "Venerable One, it follows that if there are no sentient beings with false minds, then there is also no abandoning and no rejection."

The Buddha declared: "When the bodhisattva has no arising from the later moment of falseness, falseness is immeasurable. When one recognizes that in mind there is no mind, there is nothing to abandon in mind. When there is no differentiation and no division, transient consciousness has no arising, and so there is nothing to abandon in arising."

That is something without abandonment, and there is no absence either. Why is this? Because there is neither the act of abandoning nor that which has been abandoned.

The bodhisattva Groltar asked the Buddha: "Venerable One, if the very act of abandoning without abandonment is itself arising, how can one say there is no arising?"

The Buddha declared: "When the bodhisattva abandons that arising, what has been abandoned is finished, and there is no further act of abandoning. Not being attached to the absence of abandoning, and not being attached even to non-attachment — in that case, what kind of arising could there be?"

The bodhisattva Groltar asked the Buddha: "Venerable One, in a mind without arising, what is there to take up and what is there to abandon? What are the defining marks of phenomena?"

The Buddha declared: "In phenomena without arising there is nothing to take up and nothing to abandon. One abides in the absence of mind, and abides in the absence of phenomena."

The bodhisattva Groltar asked the Buddha: "Venerable One, how does one abide in the absence of mind and abide in the absence of phenomena?"

The Buddha declared: "When mind has not arisen, one abides in the absence of mind. O virtuous man, when the phenomena of mind have not arisen, there is no abiding and no support. When one is not attached to any activity whatsoever, mind is primordially empty and unmoved, and there is no mind that is other or separate. The analogy is space: there is no movement and no stillness, no aversion, no action, no mutual opposition — and so one attains the eye of emptiness in mind, and attains the body of empty phenomena. Through this, all five aggregates (skandhas) and the totality of the six sense sources are empty and unmoved."

"O virtuous man, one who practises the empty phenomena does not rely on the three realms, is not attached to the defining marks of moral discipline, and, having no mind toward purity, there is nothing gathered and nothing abandoned. Since one's essential nature is like a vajra, the Three Jewels are indestructible. Because the empty phenomena are unmoved, one is endowed with the six perfections."

The bodhisattva Groltar asked the Buddha: "Venerable One, if all six perfections are without defining marks, can one pass beyond the world

through phenomena without defining marks?"

The Buddha declared: "O virtuous man, the six perfections as I have explained them are without defining marks and without activity. Why is this? Because the skilled one enters into freedom from desire, mind is ever pure, and through the skillful means of truthful words one benefits both oneself and others — that is the perfection of generosity.

When from a pure mind one is able to endure, and mind has no permanent abiding, unstained in body and without defilement, and unattached to the three realms — that is the perfection of moral discipline.

When one practises emptiness and cuts the knots, not relying on existing things, the three actions are empty and unmoved, and one is not attached to body or mind — that is the perfection of patience.

When one is entirely freed from counting by names, and cuts the view of seeing as empty and as existent, and enters deeply into the emptiness of the aggregates — that is the perfection of diligence.

When emptiness and unmovability are both free from coloring, one is not attached to anything whatsoever of emptiness, and one abides in the great emptiness in which mind has no resting place — that is the perfection of meditative concentration.

When there is no perception of mind in mind, no attachment to emptiness, no arising in any activity whatsoever, no abiding in emptiness and stillness either, no entering and exiting in mind, and by virtue of one's essential nature being in perpetual equanimity, one does not abide in the unchanging essential nature of the true basic space of phenomena, and is not attached even to wisdom — that is the perfection of wisdom.

O virtuous man, through such six perfections one attains the patience of the final moment, and by entering into the essential nature of the truly unchanging one rises beyond the world and attains realization. That is the liberation of Groltar."

O virtuous man, the defining mark of the Dharma of such liberation is to dwell in the mark. Yet there is no liberation and no attachment either — that is what is called liberation.

How so? In the defining mark of liberation there is no defining mark, no activity, no movement, no agitation. When in the nirvāṇa of empty, unmoving stillness one is not even attached to the mark of nirvāṇa — upon hearing these

words, the bodhisattva Groltar attained something never before experienced, and his mind was filled with great joy. He composed himself in mind and spoke in verse:

The great color that spread through the venerable one,
leading many ordinary beings —
all of it is said to be the single vehicle,
and yet there is no path of the three vehicles.

Of one taste, markless, gathering benefit,
like the example of the great emptiness:
nothing resides, nothing is withheld, nothing contained,
each thing's intrinsic nature distinct.

All attain the ultimate abode.

Through separation from mind and from I-ness,
the foundation of the single Dharma is established.

Those who practice in accord and those who practice in distinction —
all attain the merit of the ultimate.

Seeing the two marks and cutting through obstruction,
empty, unmoving, nirvāṇa is reached.

Through taking up and reasoning without attachment,
those who enter the abode of the Sage —
they are without mark and without activity,
through empty mind, unmoving, at peace:
emptiness stilled, mind does not arise,
equal to the vajra's essential nature.

The Three Jewels are inexhaustible.

Possessed of the six perfections,
one thoroughly liberates all sentient beings,
arising in and passing beyond the abode of the three realms,
yet none of them practice a single vehicle exclusively.

Sealed by the Dharma of one taste,
the single vehicle is accomplished and complete.

Then the many ordinary beings, having heard this teaching expounded, were filled with great joy in their minds. Attaining freedom from mind and I-ness, they entered into the emptiness that is without mark. Vast and spacious beyond measure, all of them completely cut the knot and attained the exhaustion of defilements.

This is the third chapter of the Dharma letters of vajra meditative absorption, the chapter on the conduct of non-arising.

At that time, the bodhisattva Sems kyi Rgyal po, King of Mind, having heard the Blessed One teach the inconceivable Dharma that goes beyond the three realms, rose from his seat, joined his palms with fingers interlaced, and asked in verse:

Through the exposition of scripture by the one who has gone to truth,
there is no form arising in the world,
and all births have been exhausted.

Has the attainment of the exhaustion of heedfulness been reached?

To hold the mind of emptiness and the māra together —
that is the absence of birth.

Yet if there is no birth, how is it
that there is a commission of non-arising?

Then the Blessed One declared to the bodhisattva Sems kyi Rgyal po, King of Mind: O virtuous man, the commission of the Dharma of non-arising means that from the ultimate there is no arising in phenomena. All activities are free of arising. If the practice of non-arising is itself absent, then the attainment of the commission of non-arising is illusory and unreal.

The bodhisattva Sems kyi Rgyal po, King of Mind, submitted: Venerable one, if the attainment of the commission of arising is illusory and unreal, then neither is there attainment nor is there commission. If neither, then indeed it accords with being illusory and unreal.

The Blessed One said: It is not so. Why? If there is neither attainment nor commission, then that indeed is the existence of attainment. If there is the existence of attainment and the existence of attachment, that is the existence of birth. If there is birth and there is attainment, then it is a Dharma in which attainment exists — and all of it is illusory and unreal.

The bodhisattva Sems kyi Rgyal po, King of Mind, submitted: Venerable one, in what way then can one say there is no commission and no birth, that the mind is illusory and unreal?

The Blessed One said: What is called "no commission, no birth, mind" is the grasping and

without characteristic mark. It is, for example, like the nature of fire: fire is indeed present within wood, yet there is no fixed location where it abides. The

intrinsic nature does not change; in reality, there is merely a name and a knower — the intrinsic nature cannot be found when sought. In order to express the meaning of that thing, if one does not speak the reflected name, the name cannot be obtained; and in the same way, the characteristic mark of mind also has no fixed location to be seen. If one recognizes that mind is just like this, then primordially there is no mind that is born.

O son of good family, the characteristic mark of the intrinsic nature of that mind is like the fruit of the āmalaka tree: it is not born from itself, not born from another, not born from both together, and it does not arise from the convergence of causes and conditions. There is no birth. Why so? Because conditions have exchanged and passed on. When conditions have stirred, there is likewise no birth. And when conditions have passed, there is no pacification — there is no characteristic mark of manifest or unmanifest.

That fruit is empty of substance and at peace. Abiding in the location of non-existence, it is not seen as a location of existence. The essential nature does not truly change; and that essential nature of not truly changing is neither one nor many, neither same nor different, neither impermanent nor annihilated, neither entering nor arising, neither born nor dying — it is devoid of denial and of ground, and the path of words that speak of it is cut off.

If the essential nature of the mind that is without birth is just like that, then in what way is there no birth? When birth, commission, and non-commission are described, and someone says that there is attainment in the mind, that there is abiding and relinquishing — through that they will not attain the unsurpassed, eternal, perfect wisdom. That is a rough-and-ready distinguishing of the essential nature of mind by night, so to speak. But if one recognizes that the essential nature of mind is just as it is, then the essential nature too is comparable to that — and there is no activity of birth.

The bodhisattva King of Mind submitted: Venerable one, if the mind does not stir from outside, then no activity of birth arises. If activities do not arise, then the non-activity of birth does not arise either. And if the absence of activity also does not arise, then primordially there is no birth.

The Buddha declared: O son of good family, if you practice non-birth, do you recognize that you are practicing non-birth?

The bodhisattva King of Mind submitted: No, venerable one. Why so? If there is no activity of birth, then the characteristic mark of essential nature is empty and unmoving — there is no seeing, no hearing, no losing, no relinquishing. In

that case, how should one be told to take up awareness? If there is awareness, then that is dispute and assertion. If there is no dispute and no assertion, then primordially there is no activity of birth.

The Buddha declared: Have you attained the unsurpassed, eternal, perfect awakening?

The bodhisattva King of Mind submitted: I have not attained the unsurpassed, eternal, perfect awakening. Why so? Within the essential nature of awakening there is no attainment, no loss, no feeling, no knowing, and no conceptual examination. Within what is free of conceptual examination is the essential nature that is pure and clean. Within that essential nature there is no obstruction, no mixture, no expression in words, no existence, no non-existence, no knowing, and no not-knowing. And since the phenomena fit to be practiced are also absent — why so? — the resting place of all practiced phenomena is not seen.

The essential nature does not truly change; and so, if primordially there is neither attainment nor non-attainment, how then can one speak of attaining the unsurpassed, eternal, perfect awakening?

The Buddha declared: It is so, it is so. Just as you have said: all the activity of mind does not transcend the absence of characteristic marks. The essential nature is empty, and there is no birth.

The consciousnesses fit to exist are likewise the same. Why so? The eye and eye-contact are empty throughout and do not stir; consciousness, too, is empty and does not stir. There is also no characteristic mark of non-stirring. Within the interior, the three takings-up are also absent; those three takings-up are empty and stilled. The ear, nose, tongue, body, mind-and-mentation, mental consciousness, the consciousness of "I," and the all-base consciousness (*ālayavijñāna*) — all of these are equally so: the mind that is empty and stilled, and the mind of non-arising, do not arise at all. If the mind that is empty and stilled, and the mind of non-arising, were to have arisen, then there would be the engagement of arising — it would not be the absence of the engagement of arising. The three interior takings-up, the three engagements, and the three forms of ethical conduct are empty and stilled by virtue of non-arising; if they have not arisen, then mind does not arise, and mind is permanently empty and stilled. There is no object and no engagement; it would also not be appropriate to have a characteristic mark of a mind that is empty and stilled — for where there is no contact, there is no attachment. One

enters without abiding; if one grasps the meaning of the signless, then from the outset the three takings-up are absent. All is empty, and the abode is pure and clean. Without attachment, one does not enter into meditative absorption (samādhi), does not enter into meditative concentration (dhyāna), and there is neither arising nor engagement.

The bodhisattva King of Mind asked: If one is able through meditative concentration to gather in agitation and to master disturbing illusions, why then should one not practice meditative concentration? The Buddha declared: The bodhisattva's meditative concentration is indeed of the nature of movement. If it does not move, it is not meditative concentration — it is the meditative concentration of non-arising. The essential nature of meditative concentration is non-arising. Meditative concentration is free from the characteristic mark of arising. There is no attachment to the essential nature of meditative concentration; when one is free from the attachment of stirring in meditative concentration, and when one knows that in the essential nature of meditative concentration there is neither stirring nor non-stirring, one attains non-arising. The wisdom of non-arising does not abide even in arising, and mind, too, does not stir. Through practicing such wisdom, one attains the Perfection of Wisdom of non-arising.

The bodhisattva King of Mind asked: Venerable One, the wisdom of non-arising has no attachment to any abode whatsoever, nor is it separated from any abode whatsoever. There is no abode in which a mind that is seated exists, and there is no seated state, and there is no mind. Mind has no arising and no seated state. Thus, a mind that is so seated has neither arising nor seated state. Venerable One, the absence of the engagement of arising in mind is inconceivable. Within the inconceivable, words cannot exhaust it. The Buddha declared: It is so.

The bodhisattva King of Mind, upon hearing those words, praised them with the words "Never before have I heard this," and then spoke these verses:

The vast and noble one of great primordial wisdom
has expounded widely the phenomena of the engagement of arising.
What I had never heard before, I have now heard;
what had not been taught before is today taught.

Like pure clear water from a spring,
it wells up from a single primordial source time and again.
It is difficult to encounter, difficult to contemplate,

and extremely difficult to hear.

The supreme and transcendent field of the unsurpassed —
the innermost and highest holiness ripens.

For the sake of liberating all sentient beings,
this liberation has been fully expounded.

Then, upon hearing those words spoken within the great assembly, everyone
attained non-arising and the wisdom of the unborn.

This is the fourth chapter of the letters of Dharma of the vajra meditative
absorption, the chapter on the merit and benefit of subsequent feeling.

At that time, the bodhisattva Vairāgya, having heard the Blessed One expound
inconceivably on the inconceivable authentic truth of the single flavor of a
buddha, came from afar and drew near. He sat in attendance upon the
Tathāgata who was present there, and listened with one-pointed mind,
examining carefully.

He entered a state of pure dwelling, and his body and mind became still and
unmoving. Then the Buddha spoke to the bodhisattva Vairāgya: "From where
have you come at the outset, and where are you now going?"

The bodhisattva Vairāgya replied: "Venerable One, I have come from that
which, from the very beginning, has no limit. And now I go to that place which
likewise has no limit."

The Buddha declared: "You have not come from any limit, and there is likewise
no place to which you have gone. You have gained limitless merit — it is
inconceivable."

Then that great bodhisattva, that bodhisattva of great being, immediately sent
forth a vast radiance that appeared to pervade the entire realm, and spoke
these verses:

Those of truly great endurance,
all are filled with wisdom, broad and deep.
Ever practicing the merit of the limitless,
they benefit and serve all sentient beings.
Practicing the four rites of conduct,
they ever abide in the merit of the limitless.
The many and the ordinary are all drawn along,
yet there is neither going nor coming.

Then the bodhisattva Vairāgya asked the Buddha: "Whatever benefit is practiced and transformed — how does it transform the minds and mentations of all sentient beings, bringing them into a pure and clear awareness?"

The Buddha declared: "The buddhas who have gone in perfect truth always practice the single feeling, and by transforming consciousness they bring beings into pure and clear awareness. How so? Because all sentient beings feel from the very beginning, one always practices this single feeling and causes the feelings of sentient beings to feel. Those sentient beings are caused to attain the primordial feeling, and their minds and mentations become empty of feeling, still and unmoving, and without arising. How so? Because the essential nature of the primordial does not truly change, there is no movement away from the primordial."

The bodhisattva Vairāgya asked: "When consciousness rises from the realm of all conditions, how is it possible for it alone to be unmoving?"

The Buddha declared: "All three realms are also empty from the very beginning. All consciousness is likewise empty from the very beginning. If consciousness has no intrinsic nature of conditionality, how could one speak of it as having risen from conditions?"

The bodhisattva Vairāgya asked: "How then does one see all realms as empty?"

The Buddha declared: "Seeing itself is not true. How so? Everything that exists is also without arising and without characteristics. From the very beginning it lacks its own name, so all is empty and unmoving, and the characteristics of all phenomena are likewise the same. The bodies of all sentient beings are also like this, and if there is no body, how can one speak of seeing?"

The bodhisattva Vairāgya said: "All realms are empty, all bodies are empty, all consciousness is empty — it follows then that feeling is also empty."

The Buddha declared: "That which is called the single feeling is not destroyed and does not tremble. The essential nature that does not truly change is neither empty nor non-empty; there is neither emptiness nor non-emptiness."

The bodhisattva Vairāgya said: "The elements of the realm are also like this — there is no characteristic of emptiness, and there is also no characteristic of emptiness being present."

The Buddha declared: "It is not so. That which is called the realm — because its primordial essential nature does not truly change, in that primordial essential nature which does not truly change there is no dwelling place."

The bodhisattva Vairāgya said: "Feeling is the same — there is no dwelling place."

The Buddha declared: "Yes, that is so. That is so. Because feeling has no dwelling place, it is utterly pure. In that utter purity there is also no feeling. Because nothing whatsoever has a dwelling place, it is utterly pure, and in that utter purity there is no color."

The bodhisattva Vairāgya said: "Mind, eye, and consciousness are also the same — it is inconceivable."

The Buddha declared: "Mind, eye, and

consciousness is also the same — it is inconceivable. How is this so? Because color has no dwelling place, it is utterly pure, and because there is no seeing, it does not arise outwardly. Because mind has no dwelling place, it is utterly pure — there is no cessation, and there is no ground from which it could arise. Because consciousness has no dwelling place, in its utter purity it does not stir. When there is no differentiation through conditions, essential nature is emptiness, unmoving. When there is no feeling in that essential nature, feeling is unfelt by feeling. O Vairāgya, if one recognizes that feeling is unfelt by virtuous feeling, the consciousnesses dissolve. Why is that? Because one enters the ground of vajra wisdom. The path of liberation is cut. When it is cut, one enters the ground of non-attachment, and there is no arising or entering. When one rests in the state where there is no abiding in mind, the essential nature does not truly change. That ground is utterly pure — like pure vaiḍūrya. The complete equalization of essential nature is like the great earth. To enter that wisdom is to enter the ground of the buddhas. When one enters the ground of wisdom, the consciousnesses are no longer born.

The bodhisattva Vairāgya submitted: "The Sugata has explained it. This is the miraculous power of a single feeling — the ground of wisdom of the four great kings. It is the root benefit and merit for all sentient beings. How is this so? Within the bodies of all sentient beings it expands from the womb outward to fullness. This is what the Buddha has said. How is this so? All sentient beings are, from the womb, undefiled. The benefit through virtuous ones being the womb benefit — the benefit of desire existing — is because it has not been gathered in or tamed."

The bodhisattva Vairāgya submitted: "For those sentient beings who have not yet obtained the benefit of the womb and who feel and gather, how are those who are difficult to tame subdued and tamed?"

The Buddha declared: "Whether sitting or going alone, whether entangled in conceptual thought, when the mind turns and one is dwelling in ruin — being gathered in and tamed, being tamed in difficulty, being freed and liberated from the bonds of māra, one awakens, and it is like sitting on a vast open plain: consciousness and the aggregates pass into nirvāṇa."

The bodhisattva Vairāgya submitted: "Having attained nirvāṇa by mind, when one is alone with no companion, by ever abiding in nirvāṇa one is of the lineage of liberation."

The Buddha declared: "If one abides in nirvāṇa, one is bound by nirvāṇa. Why is that? Nirvāṇa is the benefit of the primal feeling. The benefit that comes from the womb is nirvāṇa. The very quality of the feeling of nirvāṇa is itself the quality of primal feeling, and the essential nature of feeling is not different, nor is nirvāṇa different. The womb of feeling is also inexhaustible, and nirvāṇa is also inexhaustible. Because of the womb of nirvāṇa, there is no attaining of nirvāṇa. If nirvāṇa is not attained, how can one speak of there being an abiding? O Vairāgya, virtuous feeling does not cling even to nirvāṇa. Why is that? Feeling, from the womb, has no arising, and sentient beings are free from defilement. Abiding in such a ground, there is no place of abiding in mind, and since there is no arising or entering, one enters the knowing of utter purity."

The bodhisattva Vairāgya submitted: "Is there a ground of entering into the knowing of utter purity? Is there an attaining of a ground? Does one thereby attain Dharma?"

The Buddha declared: "It is like this. It is comparable to a child in training — when a gold earring is in one's hand, one does not know it is there, and one traverses the ten directions for fifty years,

Living in poverty and greatly afflicted, he sustained himself only by begging, yet he could not fill even one person's needs. Then his father, seeing him in such a state, spoke to the son: "Child, why do you carry a gold earring and neither take it up nor make use of it? Why do you not let it serve whatever you need, to your heart's content?" The son remembered, found the gold earring, was overjoyed in his heart, and said, "I have found an earring!" The father,

instructing the son in training, said: "Do not rejoice! The finding of the gold earring is your own wealth — you did not find it from somewhere outside yourself. How is it fitting to rejoice?"

The knowing of utter purity, too, is exactly the same. It has no characteristic mark arising from without, and it has not been entered just now for the first time. It was not absent before due to prior training. Because it is now perceived, it is said to be entered for the first time.

The bodhisattva Vairāgya submitted: "When the father saw that the son was in training, what did he teach? For fifty years the son traversed the ten directions, greatly afflicted by poverty — was that the first declaration?"

The Buddha declared: "What is called 'fifty years' means that with a single moment of thought, the mind is stirred. 'Traversing the ten directions' means having gone far, becoming attached to pervasiveness."

The bodhisattva Vairāgya submitted: "How is it that with a single moment of thought the mind is stirred?"

The Buddha declared: "When the mind is stirred by a single moment of thought, the five aggregates (skandhas) arise all at once. Within those five arisen aggregates, all fifty evils are complete."

The bodhisattva Vairāgya submitted: "When one has gone far and become attached to pervasiveness, when one traverses the ten directions, and when with a single moment of thought the mind arises and all fifty evils are complete — in that case, how can these sentient beings prevent a single moment of thought from arising?"

The Buddha declared: "Those sentient beings must let the mind rest in truth. Abiding on the vajra ground, the mind is unstirred. Because there is no arising, the mind is permanently at ease and open, and there is no single moment of thought."

The bodhisattva Vairāgya submitted: "It is inconceivable. If the mind of feeling does not arise, then that mind is at ease and open — this is the patient endurance of feeling arising from without. Since there is no stirring in this patience, it is permanent and is not absent. Yet the absent is also present. Nor is there an absence of feeling. If one recognizes, through feeling itself, the absence of feeling, that is merit arising from without and feeling arising from without. Since pure, clear feeling is without stain, it does not change and does not turn back. Since the essential nature does not truly change, it is

inconceivable." The Buddha declared: "That is so."

When the bodhisattva Vairāgya heard these words and heard what had never been heard before, he spoke a verse:

The venerable great teacher has explained
the arising of Dharma without thought.

The mind arises not, and there is no thought;
the mind ever arises, yet there is no peace.

One perceiving — merit of feeling arising from without —
is like the finding of the gold earring.

The very finding is itself no finding.

Thereupon the many who heard these words spoken all attained the merit of feeling arising from without — the Perfection of Wisdom.

This is the fifth chapter on the letters of the Dharma of vajra meditative absorption, the chapter on entering into the true sphere of reality.

Then the Tathāgata declared these words: "Henceforth, sentient beings who are fit vessels should also explain this Dharma in this way at other times in future. Time and patience do not arise together. There is no conformity in what is said to be contradictory or non-contradictory; there is also no difference. Marks, too, should be explained in just that way. Drawing wisdom by the mind of all,

drawn into the ocean of omniscient primordial wisdom, the fit ones are trained as though by the wind of emptiness; yet without having done so in that way, the mass of ordinary beings is entirely the magical display of a single flavor. Strive to attain what has not yet been attained! With respect to dwelling in what has a world and what has no world, and with respect to the place of dwelling having none, entering into arising within the five emptinesses — there is nothing to be taken up or cast aside. How is this so? Phenomena are empty of marks; the essential nature of phenomena is not absent. Yet that absence of absence is also not the case. If there is no absence, then the absence of existence and non-existence is also absent. The essential nature that is authentic and unchanging does not cling to existence and non-existence, and that existence and non-existence is likewise absent. Ordinary conventional wisdom and magical wisdom can infer the ultimate from the outside. If bodhisattvas and those like them recognize merit of that kind, they will attain awakening at the very beginning.

At that time, among the ordinary assembly there was a bodhisattva named Great Power who rose from his seat and openly addressed the Buddha: "Venerable Sugata, with respect to the five emptinesses, there is no arising and entering, and there is nothing to be taken up or cast aside." The Buddha declared: "What is called the five emptinesses of awakening is this: the three existents are empty, the obscurations of the six paths are empty, the marks of phenomena are empty, name and form are empty, and the basis of the consciousness of mind is empty.

A bodhisattva such as this does not abide in emptiness upon emptiness, for within emptiness there is no form of emptiness. In a phenomenon that has no form, what is there to take up or cast aside? When one arrives at the place where there is nothing to take up, one arrives ultimately at emptiness itself."

The bodhisattva Great Power asked: "In what way should we speak of the three emptinesses?" The Buddha declared: "What is called the three emptinesses is this: the mark of emptiness is also empty, the emptiness of emptiness is also empty, and the abode of emptiness is also empty. Because of not clinging to these three marks and so forth, authentic truth is not absent. The path of letters and words is cut; it is inconceivable."

The bodhisattva Great Power asked: "If authentic truth is not absent, then it would seem that its marks are present." The Buddha declared: "The non-existent does not cling to non-existence. It is neither non-existent nor existent, and in phenomena that are not existent there is no clinging to non-existence. The mark of what is not non-existent does not cling to existence. An explanation that expounds a basis in terms of existence and non-existence is not something that can be attained.

The mark of the bodhisattva's basis of namelessness is inconceivable. How is this so? The name of the nameless is not itself nameless. The basis of the baseless is not itself without a basis."

The bodhisattva Great Power said: "Such name and basis are indeed the mark of the immovable authentic truth." The Buddha declared: "The immovable mark of the Sugata does not cling to immovability. In immovability there is no mark of immovability. If immovability had a mark, would that not mean it was not the Sugata? The mark of the minds of sentient beings is not the mark of the Sugata, and it is fitting that the minds of sentient beings also have no distinction of elements." The Buddha declared: "That is so. The minds of sentient beings are, in truth, without any distinction of elements. Why? It is

because the ultimate of sentient beings is pure. In the eternal, if there is no arising, then it is named, owing to defilement by dust, 'the three realms.' The minds of the three realms are called 'the element of distinct names,' and that element is a magical illusion, untrue, arising because mind has taken on the form of a body. If there is no untruth arising from mind, then there is also no element of distinction."

The bodhisattva Great Power said: "When the mind is pure, the constituents of the elements do not arise."

It is from mind that the three realms arise — this is what the Buddha has taught. In the bodhisattva, no elements arise from mind, and no mind arises from the elements. Why? Because whatever of the elements appears to be seen is nothing but mind being seen; and if the magical illusion has not been fabricated by mind, then nothing whatsoever is seen. For the bodhisattva, there are no sentient beings within or without. When the three intrinsic natures are empty and unmoved, there is from the very beginning no such thing as "I" or "we," and no such thing as "colour" — and if even the mind of what is called "the two entrances" and all that follows from them does not arise, then through the attainment of such traversal, the three realms are likewise, from the very beginning, absent.

The bodhisattva Great Power asked: "How can one say that the two entrances have not arisen from mind? If they do not arise from the primal depth of mind, how can one say that entrance exists?"

The Buddha declared: "What are called the two entrances — the first is entrance through the teaching, and the second is entrance through practice. Entrance through the teaching means placing full and genuine trust in the fact that the essential nature of all sentient beings is undifferentiated. Though they are neither one nor in harmony, nor other nor in discord, they are veiled and severed by outer dust. Neither past nor future — abiding in meditative absorption in the entrance through feeling, and investigating so as to realize the essential nature of buddha: there is no existence and no non-existence, no self and no other, no ordinary and no magical display. Dwelling firm on the ground of the vajra mind, unchanging, empty, unmoved, and without purity. It is not established from a gathering of signs, nor from bare simplicity alone. It is not merely bare. It has not assembled, not scattered, not arisen, not died. There is no sign of coming, going, or assembling. It is inconceivable. This is what the Buddha has taught. It is inconceivable. And the mind that is

inconceivable is likewise so. Why? Because in the unmoved mind there is no differentiation; for from its primal depth, mind is unmoved — and so the essential nature of sentient beings and the essential nature of buddha are neither one nor different. The essential nature of mind is, from its primal depth, free of birth and death. The nirvāṇa of the essential nature of birth and death is itself the essential nature: the sign of essential nature is unmoved from its primal depth, and because what is unmoved has no movement, the signs of all phenomena do not arise from conditions. The essential nature of the sign of arising is unmoved. In what is unmoved there is no movement whatsoever, for the sign of the essential nature of conditions is empty from its primal depth. When there is nothing, no conditions arise from condition upon condition, and from emptiness upon emptiness. All phenomena of conditions are seen as untrue signs by a mind that has been corrupted. In the manifest, they do not arise from the primal depth. Because conditions have been absent from the primal depth, the doctrinal ground of the unmoved mind is the absence of any emptiness of one's own essential nature. It is comparable to the sovereign of emptiness: when there is no dwelling place established from the primal depth, it is seen through the ordinary mind's conceptual examination of truth. In the signs of the truly unmoved, existence and non-existence are present from the primal depth. The sign of existence and non-existence is seen by mind's consciousness alone. The dharma of the bodhisattva's unmoved mind is neither one without its own essential nature, nor one with an essential nature — it neither comes nor acts. For the bodhisattva, the sign of absence and non-action has no ground to be expressed in words. Why? Because the truly unmoved dharma is vast and empty; since it has no sign, it is not known by the duality. The element of emptiness is not known by outer or inner awareness — yet through the defilement of the six senses, it can be known from the beginning."

The bodhisattva of Great Power asked: "How should what is called 'practicing the six' be explained? I request that this be set forth."

The Buddha declared: "The first is practicing the ten of faith. The second is practicing the ten abodes. The third is practicing the ten conducts. The fourth is practicing the ten transferences and directions. The fifth is the ten of completion. The sixth is practicing the equalized feeling — for when one reflects for a single moment, the mind does not become genuinely distorted, and so it is clearly luminous. Through the power of vajra wisdom, by reaching out within a single lifetime, sentient beings are liberated from bondage; and

loving-kindness and compassion are without depth."

The bodhisattva of Great Power asked: "A person of that kind would presumably not grasp at even a single rule of moral discipline, and monks too would presumably show no reverence for painted images."

The Buddha declared: "To those who are non-virtuous, lazy, and like the waves and surf upon the ocean of the mind, moral discipline is taught. But the ocean of awareness adorned by the mind — the awareness of pure reverence — falls clear and still. The wind is unable to stir it; waves and surf do not rise within it. Since the essential nature of moral discipline is comparable to emptiness, those who grasp at it are misled and in error. One of that description, at the thirteenth and fourteenth stages, does not take birth. The assemblages are halted and mastered; one is not separated from the three buddhas. Moving through awakening, one enters wholly, as by the mind itself, into the three marked by absence of signs, and one is utterly reverent toward the Three Jewels. Not having lost the rite, there is no reverent regard for painted images among the practitioners of virtue. That bodhisattva, in this very way, is unattached to the Dharma of the world's moving and unmoved; having entered into the aggregate of the three emptinesses, the mind of the three existences is at peace."

The bodhisattva of Great Power asked: "By this one, having perfected all fruits, one obtains the treasury of the Well-Gone Buddha (Sugata). Through the form and body of a buddha one becomes a buddha; and from such a buddha's abode, moving through awakening, one fully absorbs the moral discipline that gathers the three. Being unattached to its signs, the mind of the three realms is at peace. Not being attached to or dwelling even in the ground of emptiness, one does not let slip what is ordinary — entering the ground that is beyond taming is inconceivable."

Thereupon Śāriputra rose from his seat and spoke a verse before the assembly:

Replete and complete in the ocean of wisdom,
skilled in nirvāṇa and unattached,
like the noble flower of the lotus —
it has not arisen for the sake of fragrance.
Through incalculable aeons of buddhas,
all turmoil of sorrow has not been relinquished.
Liberating the world, one attains the primordial —

like a lotus risen from the mud.
That ground of the one who practices the six
is the conduct of the bodhisattva.
That aggregate of the three emptinesses
is the straight path to awakening.
Set in place without attachment to what is low,
as the Buddha has declared it:
what has come returns again;
complete, it arises from its primordial source.
All sentient beings, of every kind,
are made to be one like me, not two.
Those who return and those who come after —
all are made to flow in the stream of the straight.

Then the Buddha declared to Śāriputra: "It is inconceivable. When you in future have accomplished the path of awakening, liberate from the ocean of the suffering of death innumerable sentient beings."

Thereupon the great multitude, all having become aware of awakening, and even those of the lesser vehicles, fully entered into the ocean of the five emptinesses.

This is the sixth chapter of the Dharma text of the Vajra Samādhi (Skt. vajrasamādhi), the chapter on the empty essential nature of reality.

The Dharma text of the Vajra Samādhi, the second and final fascicle.

At that time Śāriputra asked the Buddha: "Venerable One, one practices the path of awakening — yet there is no name and no form, and there is also no rite of the three moral disciplines. How, then, in brief, should one take this up and explain it to sentient beings? With the Buddha's loving-kindness and compassion for me, I request that it be set forth and explained."

The Buddha declared:

"Listen, man of virtue, and I shall explain it to you. Man of virtue, the phenomena of virtue and non-virtue arise and are born from the mind. All elements are differentiated through mind and speech. When they are confined to a single place, the many conditions are cut off and gone. How is this? Man of virtue, if a single final instant does not waver, then the three modes of conduct have nothing to engage in. If one abides in the ground of non-wavering, the

doors of the six destinies are sealed. If one does not depart from conditions as they are, the rites of the three disciplines are complete."

Śāriputra asked: "How is it that not departing from conditions as they are fulfils all three disciplines?"

The Buddha declared: "To that I will respond with what is called the four conditions. First, through the condition of the power of what has been done, the proper tradition of the rites of moral discipline is gathered. Second, from the final instant onward, through the power of patience — the purity of patience, with its sharp root — when all shifting conditions are purified, by practicing the Dharma of virtue in just that way, one becomes capable of recognizing it from the very beginning."

The bodhisattva of great power then asked: "If there is no arising and entering from the arising of the experiential sense of the true basic space, then how can the phenomena of 'whatever there is' be suitably penetrated through the mind into the true basic space?"

The Buddha declared: "The phenomena of the basic space are themselves without a basic space, and it is by a mind that is itself without a basic space that one thereby penetrates into the true basic space from the very beginning."

The bodhisattva of great power asked: "The gnosis of a mind without a basic space is without compare. By a mind without compare, the mind attains independence, and by independent gnosis, would it not be suitable to penetrate into the true basic space? Consider, for example, an ordinary person with a weak and feeble mind — if such a mind has much movement of breath, whatever Dharma one practices that is mastered and can be borne is to be regarded as a mind of patient forbearance, and one would suitably penetrate into the true basic space."

The Buddha declared: "The breath of the mind of that bodhisattva, deployed in inner and outer activity, falls and moves as it is sent out, so that droplets cause a lake to rise up, and when the wind of the sky stirs and agitates it, a great nāga is startled and alarmed. Being startled and alarmed in this way, the mind causes the breath to move abundantly. If that bodhisattva, that sentient being, does not let the three decline and guards the one, then they penetrate into the meditative concentration of the Sugata (the Well-Gone One), and by practicing the meditative concentration of that meditative concentration with capability, the mind is without breath."

The bodhisattva of great power asked: "How is it that not letting the three decline and guarding the one constitutes penetrating into the meditative concentration of the Sugata?"

The Buddha declared: "Not letting the three decline means not letting the three liberations decline. Guarding the one means guarding the single unmoving mind. Penetrating into the meditative concentration of the Sugata means that by a mind steadily affixed to the ground in such a way, one penetrates into the true basic space."

The bodhisattva of great power asked: "What is the meaning of 'whatever there is' with regard to the phenomena of the three liberations? And into what phenomena does the meditative absorption that is steadily affixed to the ground enter?"

The Buddha declared: "The three liberations are the liberation of emptiness, the liberation of the vajra, and the liberation of wisdom. Steadily affixed to the ground means: when the mind is pure and the ground is pure — is it then appropriate to speak of there being no mind?"

The bodhisattva of great power asked: "How does one practice without declining? How does one examine?"

The Buddha declared: "When the mind is without duality, then the practice of not declining operates within the practice itself. That which arises on the outside enters without duality. If one does not cling even to the mark of the one, there is nothing to be gained or abandoned. Without anything called 'one and yet another,' and without holding the paired precepts of separate and distinct rules, one has not yet entered into fully abandoning the self — and yet one can practice through one's own mind. Without any activity, the magical fruit of self-awakening is attained. Not abiding in either of the two vehicles, one penetrates into the path of awakening, and in the end, through a buddha who fully arises, awakening is accomplished."

The bodhisattva Mahābala asked: "It is inconceivable! A person such as this has not gone forth from the household, and yet has not remained in it either. How is that?" The Buddha declared: "Such a person has entered the household of nirvāṇa. They have put on the Dharma-robe of the Tathāgata. They abide in the teaching of the bodhisattva. A person such as this is one to whom even monks and below should respectfully offer alms. This is what the Buddha has declared. How so? By entering the household of nirvāṇa, the mind passes

beyond the three realms. By wearing the robe of the Tathāgata, one arrives at the abode of the emptiness of phenomena. By abiding in the teaching of awakening, one ascends to the ground of authentic feeling. When the mind of such a person has passed beyond the duality of self, what need is there even to speak of a monk respectfully offering alms?"

The bodhisattva Mahābala asked: "Is it not the case that a person of the two vehicles cannot see that one ground and the ocean of emptiness?" The Buddha declared: "It is so. A person of the two vehicles is one who holds to the body of meditative absorption. With regard to that one ground and the ocean of emptiness, it is comparable to one who has contracted the illness of drink — one gets intoxicated, and even though one may sober up, throughout countless aeons one still does not feel it. Only when the drink is fully digested does one feel it at last. Through practicing this conduct from the very beginning, one later attains the body of a buddha. As an analogy: such a person, having relinquished wrong craving, enters into the six kinds of conduct, and from the ground of that conduct, gathers the precepts. Third, through the power of the condition of great compassion — the wisdom of the later tradition — one gathers the precepts of sentient beings' moral discipline. Fourth, through the power of the condition of wisdom that practices the one feeling, one abides there in a similarly unshakeable way. These are called the four conditions. When such a virtuous man, through the power of these four great conditions, is not attached to the characteristics of meaning, there is no essential nature to be found, and being free from any single fixed abode, it cannot be sought and discovered.

Such a virtuous man, through a single meaning, encompasses within practice the six kinds of conduct, and this is the ocean of the awakening wisdom of a buddha."

Śāriputra (Skt. Śāriputra) said: "When one is not attached to the characteristics of meaning, there is no ego to speak of, and there is the true permanent bliss and purity of the Dharma. Having passed beyond the duality of self, it is the great nirvāṇa, so the mind is not attached to anything whatsoever. It is of great power. Within the feeling of one who has entered thus, it is fitting that there be the thirty-seven Dharmas of the chapter on the path. The Buddha has declared this to be so. There are thirty-seven Dharmas of the chapter on the path: the four foundations of mindfulness, the four correct exertions, the four bases of mental power, the five faculties, the five strengths, the seven factors of awakening, the path of the eightfold noble way,

and so forth. Although the names are many, the underlying principle is one, so they are not identical yet they are not distinct. When counted by name, they are exhausted as names and namers, yet it is appropriate to attain the Dharma. The Dharma through which it is not appropriate to attain is the one in which there is no letter in the underlying principle. The underlying principle that has no characteristic of letters is the essential nature of the emptiness of true and authentic reality. The underlying principle of the essential nature of emptiness is the authentic and unshakeable truth. The underlying principle of authentic unshakeableness is possessed of all phenomena. When a virtuous man abides in the authentic underlying principle, he passes beyond the ocean of the three kinds of suffering."

Śāriputra said: "All phenomena without exception are words and letters. The form of words and letters is itself the underlying principle — there is no principle other than that. But if the underlying principle of authentic truth cannot be expressed in words, how did the Tathāgata teach the Dharma?"

The Buddha declared: "When I taught the Dharma, it was taught for the sake of you sentient beings, and what was left over in the speaking of it was the teaching of that which cannot be expressed — the inexpressible was expressed."

"Therefore it is called 'speaking.' Everything I have spoken consists of words of underlying principle, and has no mere letters. What sentient beings call speaking consists of words of mere letters, and has no underlying principle. Words lacking the underlying principle are utterly empty. Phenomena that are empty through absence are words lacking the underlying principle. Words that accord with the underlying principle are the emptiness of the true — not the empty. Even emptiness and truth do not ultimately exist: they are free from the two characteristics. Neither an intermediate nor an absence of an intermediate exists; phenomena that are without an intermediate are free from the three characteristics, and no abiding is seen in them. This is taught as conforming to authentic immovability. In immovability, neither existence nor non-existence is present. Non-existence, too, is absent. In immovability, the absence of existence and non-existence is present. Existence-and-non-existence, existence, and non-existence have no abiding. Because there is no abiding, one abides in immovability. And since immovability itself contains no immovability, it is not said that immovability is absent."

Śāriputra asked: "Even if all sentient beings dwell in the ranks of wrong craving and such, do they attain the Tathāgata and the characteristic mark of the truth of the Tathāgata?"

The Buddha declared: "From the mind of wrong craving, arriving at the Tathāgata and the characteristic mark of the truth of the Tathāgata takes place within five ranks. The first is the rank of faith: one has faith that the seed of authentic immovability within this body is obscured by the untrue, and when the mind clinging to the untrue is relinquished, the mind becomes clear and pure, and one recognizes that the constituents are distinguished from one another by mind and word. The second is the rank of contemplation: when contemplation is examined among the ranks, it is nothing but mind and word; once mind and word are distinguished and the mind appears manifestly as one wishes, all the constituents one sees are not the cognition of an ultimate, outer dimension. In this outer-dimension cognition there is neither Dharma nor underlying principle, and one recognizes that all that could be grasped cannot be grasped. The third is the rank of conduct: when that which can perpetually move does move, at the time of harmonious movement, having first been led by wisdom, the obscurations and obstructions are cleared away, and one is free from covering and entanglement. The fourth is the rank of practice: it is free from the grounds of what has been practiced, and the mind has neither grasping nor relinquishing; rooting oneself in utter purity, with the mind unmoved, one reaches the great nirvāṇa, the expanse of truth that does not transform into the authentic — which is nothing but the great emptiness of essential nature. The fifth is the rank of equanimity: equanimity does not abide even in the wisdom of straightforwardness in the emptiness of essential nature; it descends into great compassion, and although it moves amid conditions, the characteristic marks do not stir. The characteristic marks, too, are not attached to immovability, and the empty mind of eternal, perfect awakening is not obtained either. The mind is without limit and without extreme; no abiding is seen — that is the arrival at the Tathāgata.

As for the virtuous men of the five ranks: they enter through a single feeling from the ultimate stage outward, and the teaching of sentient beings proceeds from the abode of the ultimate."

Śāriputra asked: "What then is meant by the abode of the ultimate?"

The Buddha declared: "When the ultimate has no abode of the ultimate, one enters bliss from the boundless edge of the abode-less ultimate, and upon

practicing awakening, whatever path of manifestation is accomplished — how is this? It is like a virtuous man grasping at emptiness with his hands: nothing is obtained, nor is there anything that is not pervaded."

Śāriputra said: "As the Venerable One has explained: before anything else in meaning, one practices the patience of the ultimate — grasping, emptiness, peace, and contemplation. Emptiness and peace are immovability. By gathering and holding the essence of all that is excellent, all phenomena are completely assembled into perfect awakening, and there is no duality. It is inconceivable. Let it be known! This Dharma is the perfection of great wisdom. It is the mantra of the Great God (Śiva). It is the mantra of great illumination. It is the unsurpassed mantra. It is the mantra of what cannot be accomplished by striving. This is what the Buddha has declared. It is so. It is so."

By the essential nature of emptiness — the unmoving, true emptiness — the knots are burned away by the fire of wisdom of emptiness, and through their absence, there is perfect equanimity. The equanimity of that evenness, together with the three feelings and the three bodies of the sublime feeling, shines clearly within the interior of the nine knowings, pure and immaculate, free of shadows.

O virtuous man, that Dharma has no cause and no condition: it is wisdom's own domain. There is no movement and no non-movement, for it is empty of the essential nature of activity. In what is established there is neither existence nor nonexistence. The very mark of emptiness is also empty.

O virtuous man, cause those sentient beings to penetrate and fully realize that teaching. When they have penetrated that teaching, it is the seeing of the Tathāgata (the thus-gone one).

Śāriputra asked: The examination of the Tathāgata's teaching belongs to those who have arrived at it, having parted from the four dhyānas, transcending what is commonly included — this was spoken by the Buddha. How is that so? It is the enumeration of the names of all phenomena, and the four dhyānas are just the same in that respect. When one sees the Tathāgata, the mind of the Tathāgata, being its own master, ever abides in peace, free from permanence. It neither arises nor fails to arise, neither enters nor fails to enter — inwardly and outwardly it is even and equal.

O virtuous man, if one examines those dhyānas, all perceptions are mastered, and because there is no non-movement, there is no mutual opposition. Why so? Because of non-movement. When one has practiced non-movement and

examines true non-movement, no realization of the mark of non-movement is seen, and thus the marks are empty and at peace. When empty and at peace, that is the foundation of non-movement. A perception such as this is capable of dhyāna — it is not dhyāna itself. Why so? Because the essential nature of dhyāna is free from the category of movement: there is no staining, no directing, no phenomenon, no diminishment. Since it is free from the categories of conceptual thought, it is in accordance with the foundation of the ultimate teaching. O virtuous man, if one who understands it in this way is capable of it, only then may it be called dhyāna.

Śāriputra said: It is inconceivable. The Tathāgata, ever practicing true non-movement, instructs sentient beings in such a true teaching, whose letters and syllables are many and whose scope is vast. Those of sharp faculties among sentient beings will be able to practice it from the outset, but it will be difficult for those of dull faculties to apply their minds to it. By what skillful means can those of dull faculties be caused to penetrate the truth?

The Buddha declared: If someone of dull faculties recites a single chapter of four lines and takes it up as a dhāraṇī, they will penetrate true reality, for all the qualities of a buddha are gathered into a single chapter.

Śāriputra said: I request that it be explained — what is meant by "a single chapter of four lines"?

Then the Venerable One explained the chapter and declared:

The teaching arisen from cause and condition —
that teaching has no existence, no nonexistence, no birth.
If there is no foundation for birth and death,
then in that teaching there is no birth and no death.

Then the great many who heard the chapter explained were all filled with the deepest joy, and upon hearing that all things are made free of birth and death, there arose in them, through wisdom, the Dharma of primordial wisdom that is empty of intrinsic nature. This is the seventh chapter of the Dharma letters of the vajra meditative absorption — the chapter of the treasury of the Tathāgata.

A noble practitioner of pure conduct from a former existence rose and addressed the Buddha: Venerable One, the foundation of birth is not covered over; the foundation of death does not arise. Such an unmoving foundation — this is the awakening of a buddha. Within the essential nature of awakening

there is no conceptual thought, no wisdom of conceptual thought.

The characteristic of what is without number in conceptual thought is covered over by conceptual thought alone. The characteristic of such a foundation is inconceivable. When there is no conceptual thought within the inconceivable, Venerable One, the number of all phenomena is immeasurable and without limit. The characteristic of phenomena that are without limit is the essential nature of the foundation of the single truth. As for the meaning of abiding in that single essential nature alone — the Buddha declared: Noble one, the inconceivable is the path of skillful means that I travel for the sake of those who have gone astray in my teaching of phenomena. The characteristic of all phenomena is the wisdom of the foundation of the single truth. How is this so? It is like a great market at which four great gates are opened simultaneously — all four great gates come together in that single market, and the many people enter as they wish. The savoring of the taste of phenomena is just like that.

The noble practitioner of pure conduct asked: If phenomena are like this, then if I abide in the savoring of the single taste of a phenomenon, it is fitting that the tastes of all phenomena are gathered there. The Buddha declared: Indeed, it is so. Indeed, it is so. How is this? The taste of the single true foundation is like a single great ocean — there is nothing that flows into it in great quantities that does not enter there. Noble one, the savoring of the taste of all phenomena is likewise like that great abundance flowing in. Though the names and categories may differ, there is nothing that cannot reach the water. Abiding in the great ocean, the many flowing streams are gathered together, and by abiding in the single taste, all tastes are assembled.

The noble practitioner of pure conduct asked: How is it that the single taste of phenomena constitutes the path of the three vehicles, and their wisdom may be called equal? The Buddha declared: Noble one, consider the rivers Koṇ, Ha, and Hohe, and the ocean — they differ in size, they differ in depth, and they differ in their names. When water abides within the Koṇ, it is called the water of the Koṇ. When it abides within the Ho, it is called the water of the Ho. When it abides within the Ha, it is called the water of the Ha. When all together abide within the ocean, it is called the water of the ocean. Phenomena are likewise — all of them abide in the unmoved truth, and the name is simply the path of the buddhas. Furthermore, noble one, if one abides in that single path of the buddhas, one does not practice the three practices. The noble practitioner of pure conduct asked: How then are the three practices to be understood? The

Buddha declared: The one is taking up practice in accordance with its meaning. The three are taking them up and practicing in accordance with the unmoved. Noble one, through such three practices, many sūtras are gathered at the gateway, and there is nothing that does not enter here through the gate of all phenomena. One who has entered this practice does not generate the characteristic of emptiness. One who has entered in such a way may rightly be called one who has entered upon the path of the Sugata. One who has entered upon the path of the Sugata — having entered and entered, has not entered.

The noble practitioner of pure conduct asked: The entry of the Sugata into the inconceivable is like obtaining a needle from a sprout — there is no fixed place of entry. When a sharp, fine needle is fashioned and the needle is obtained, there is wisdom in the attainment of the limit of the needle's truth. The Buddha declared: That wisdom is innumerable; to give just a brief account, there are four kinds of wisdom. What are the four? The first is the wisdom of the sage, which is like the unmoved. The second is the wisdom of transformation, which is destroyed by skillful means. The third is the wisdom of nirvāṇa, which dispels the sensation of lightning. The fourth is the wisdom of the ultimate expanse, which enters the pure path of authentic ritual.

Noble one, these four great meanings of that kind were declared by the buddhas of the past — they are profoundly great. If sentient beings are taught, this is the wisdom that is to be practiced. Noble one, it is the great holy life (brahmacarya). Furthermore, there are three great meanings. The first: the three meditative absorptions do not harm one another, inner and outer being as one. The second: the great central text is spread out for the assembly like a road, and thereby clarified. The third: the unmoved wisdom of the Sage (muni) is sharp in both compassion and wisdom together. By means of these three meanings, the awakening of that kind is accomplished and attained. If these meanings are not practiced, wisdom cannot descend in that way, and the great māras will find their opportunity.

Noble one, you and the many others should always practice the holy life without interruption until the attainment of buddhahood, and should not let even a single moment pass empty. Noble Brahmacarya then asked: What is meant by the three meditative absorptions? The Buddha declared: What are called the three meditative absorptions are the meditative absorption of emptiness, the meditative absorption of signlessness, and the meditative absorption of wishlessness. Such are the three meditative absorptions.

Noble Brahmacharya then asked: What is meant by the assembly of the great central text circling? The Buddha declared: It is the assembly that circles through the great text of the four — the aggregates (skandhas), the elements (dhātus), the sense sources (āyatanas), and so forth. It is the great assembly of the central text through the consciousness of the latter.

Noble Brahmacharya then asked: The aim of such inconceivable wisdom benefits oneself and benefits others; having transcended the ground of the elements, one is not attached even to nirvāṇa, and enters the path of awakening. The defining characteristic of such phenomena is the nature of birth and death; when freed from conceptual thought, phenomena are unquieted.

The Sugata (the Well-Gone) then taught the training in this text through verse:

Phenomena arise from conceptual thought,
and are again checked by conceptual thought.
When the phenomena of conceptual thought are checked,
those phenomena have no birth, death, or quiescence.

Then Noble Brahmacharya, having heard the teaching of this chapter, was supremely glad in mind and spoke this verse, training in this text:

All phenomena are ultimately empty and quiescent.
The quiescent empty is without arising.
Other phenomena arise and perish.
This phenomenon has no absence of arising.
These two are incompatible,
because of annihilation, permanence, and existence.
This is free from the two extremes
and does not admit even a single word.
When one declares that a single phenomenon exists,
it is like a wheel of body-hair of that one —
like water in a mirage, deceptive —
for illusions are not real.

To see phenomena as absent
is in accordance with seeing phenomena as empty.
Like a blind person without eyes on either side,
phenomena are like hair on a tortoise.
Hear what I myself have heard the Buddha teach:
recognize that in phenomena there is no seeing of duality,

and do not be attached to the Middle Way either.
It is because of attachment that it is grasped,
yet the Sugata taught the Dharma —
all arising from non-attachment, without clinging.
Resting in non-attachment myself,
I bow in reverence to the Sugata.
With respect I bow to the Sugata,
whose wisdom is unmoved, like emptiness.
Without attachment to non-attachment,
with reverence I bow to the body of non-attachment.
In every place and at all times
I constantly see the Sugatas.
By seeing the Sugatas,
may they teach me the everlasting Dharma.

The Sugata then spoke these words: You virtuous ones, listen, for this has been examined and concerns you and the many. A Dharma of examination has been taught to you and the many. As for the virtuous one, in the Dharma of examination there is no Dharma of non-examination, no syllable, no truth, and no liberation.

Neither does absence exist, nor does the element exist. Free from the extremes of annihilation that are untrue, this Dharma is such that there is no absence of permanence. Being free from those who see permanence and annihilation, consciousness is directly seen to be permanent. Consciousness is permanently empty and at peace, and that emptiness and peace is itself empty and at peace. O virtuous man, if one understands emptiness and peace, one does not become empty. The mind that is non-empty and non-peaceful is permanently empty and at peace. If emptiness and peace is attained, the mind permanently enters correctly, and if one knows names and forms, it is nothing but a mind of delusion. Through the deluded mind examining and analyzing phenomena into their distinctions, there is nothing different from one another, for they arise from nothing but names and forms. If one understands that phenomena are like this, one is not led astray by syllables and words, and neither mind nor the text of mind gives rise to conceptual thought toward me. If one understands that I am a person of illusion, one thereby attains what is primordially empty and at peace. If one attains what is empty and at peace, one thereby attains from the very beginning the unsurpassed, eternal,

complete awakening.

Then Brahmā of noble conduct, having heard those words spoken, spoke these verses:

Analyzed from names and forms,
this is called the name of Dharma and the three.
True, unmoved, straight wisdom —
combined with these it becomes five.

Those who now, by this Dharma I have taught,
are bound and examined in annihilation and permanence
and enter the path of birth and death —
that annihilation is not permanence.

The well-gone one practiced the empty Dharma
and thus is entirely free from annihilation and permanence.
Without cause and condition, no birth arises,
and without arising, there is no cessation.

Grasping that cause and condition exist
is like gathering flowers of emptiness.
As an example: like gathering flowers,
it is not at all possible to reach an extreme.

Free from those who have taken up causes and conditions,
peace does not come from anything other,
nor does it belong to one's own text.
Through unmoved reliance, happiness is attained —
this is the Dharma of genuine truth.

Permanently autonomous and unmoved,
knowing the exhaustion of all phenomena completely,
it is an emanation conjured by the magic of karma.
Without wisdom, the nature of reality is empty,
and so it is taught from the ground of emptiness.

Having covered over the Dharma of birth and death,
one abides passed beyond sorrow.
Gathered by great compassion,
one is not attached to nirvāṇa.

Through transformation, one is able to take it up
and enters the treasury of the well-gone one.

Then, when the many had heard that text spoken thus, all attained the first life and entered the well-gone one correctly, becoming worthy of the treasury of the well-gone one. This is the eighth chapter of the Dharma letters of the vajra meditative absorption, the chapter on the sūtra holder.

At that time the bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha rose from among the many, went before the Buddha, joined his palms, and kneeling down, addressed the Buddha: Venerable one, upon my examining the many, I have a concern about sentient beings who have not yet been tamed. I ask that the well-gone one clear away my concern. If so, for the sake of the many I wish to ask in accordance with that concern, and I hope that the Buddha Maitreya will look upon me with compassion and grant this.

The Buddha declared: O bodhisattva, great being, since you hold such concern for sentient beings and are able to liberate them, such great compassion is inconceivable. Ask broadly, and I shall explain and liberate it for you.

The bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha asked: How is it that all phenomena whatsoever do not arise from conditions?

Then the well-gone one, intending to explain this text, spoke in verse:

If phenomena arise from conditions,
then without conditions, would phenomena be absent?
In what way would the nature of phenomena be absent?
By what conditions do phenomena arise?

Then the bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha asked: If phenomena do not arise, why is it said in the teaching that they arise from mind?

Then the venerable one explained in verse:

A phenomenon that arises from mind
is able to take up what is to be taken up.
As an example, it is like an eye afflicted with a visual disorder
seeing flowers in empty space.
To describe these phenomena as having an essential nature
is not on a par with them.

Then the bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha asked: If that is how phenomena are, there is abiding in phenomena, and if there is no abiding, that would be consistent with phenomena being thoroughly established.

Then the venerable one explained in verse:

Phenomena have no origin whatsoever.

Self and other are likewise.

There is no beginning and no end.

One does not cling to establishment or to peace.

Then the bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha asked: The characteristic of all phenomena whatsoever is from the very beginning beyond sorrow, beyond nirvāṇa, and the characteristic of emptiness is likewise. The absence of phenomena of that kind and so forth accords with phenomena being unmoving.

The Buddha declared: Phenomena of that kind being absent — those phenomena are unmoving.

The bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha asked: It is inconceivable. The characteristic of such unmovingness has neither concordance nor discordance. Whatever is taken up by mind and whatever is taken up by action — all of it is empty and unmoving. The mind of emptiness and unmovingness, together with phenomena and yet not identical with them, is workable and consistent with the category of empty peace.

Then the venerable one explained in verse:

Phenomena that are empty and unmoving
are not unmoving and not empty along with phenomena.
When that mind is unmoving,
there is no mind that is attained by it.

The bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha asked: Since there is no truth in those phenomena, even the mind of empty appearance is at peace. Since those phenomena have been at peace from the very beginning, that is consistent with those phenomena being peace. But then, if even peace is absent, how can one speak of a unity?

Then the venerable one explained in verse:

Phenomena abide without any dwelling place.
Form and number are empty and absent.
Name and description — these two things, phenomena,
cannot be taken up.

Then the bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha asked: The characteristic of all phenomena whatsoever clings to neither of the two edges and clings not even to the flow of the middle. If consciousness too is similar to that, how can it be said that the consciousnesses of the elements arise from consciousness? If consciousness

were to have arising, how could that consciousness, itself having come from arising, be said to be without arising, when all that has arising can arise?

Then the venerable one explained in verse:

Arising and the capacity to arise — these two —
can be conditioned by what?

From the beginning, both are absent.

It is like taking an empty-causal flower.

Consciousness has not arisen,
and the elements too are not arisen at that time.

When the elements have not arisen,
at that time consciousness is at peace.

Moreover, from the beginning there is no limit.

Existence, nonexistence, and both — none of these obtain.

Even a cognition of non-arising is absent.

So how, from that, could the elements exist?

Then the bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha asked: Such being the characteristic of phenomena, and both inner and outer being empty, the elements and wisdom are both from the very beginning empty and at peace. In what the Sugata (the well-gone one, an epithet of the Buddha) has taught, the characteristic of truth is genuine emptiness. Such phenomena are not composite. The Buddha declared: Such an unmoving, genuine phenomenon has no form, no attachment, no aggregation whatsoever, no capacity to aggregate, no framework, and no magnitude.

This is a Dharma teaching of one final cycle — the aggregate of profound meaning, excellent and deep.

The bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha asked: In the inconceivable aggregate, seven and five do not arise. Eight and six are empty and at peace. Nine has no characteristic whatsoever that is empty. Nor is there an emptiness of absence. As the Venerable One has taught, all the foundations of Dharma are empty. When one enters emptiness, there is no practice. Since the various karmas are not lost, self and the place of self, the place of capacity, the seeing of the body, and inward and outward homage — when examined, all are empty and unmoving. I aspire that teachings of such pure foundations, wisdom, and true unmoving may be proclaimed. That the Venerable One ever thus teaches the genuinely unmoving, empty Dharma of truth is excellent medicine. This is what the Buddha has declared.

Why is this so? Because of emptiness. In the essential nature of emptiness there is no arising. In the mind there is, permanently, no arising. In the essential nature of emptiness there is no peace, and in the mind likewise there is no activity. There is no arising or entering of karma from emptiness. Being separated from the accumulations of attainment and emptiness, the aggregates, the elements, and what has entered — all of these too do not exist. That the mind is unmoving and without attachment is likewise the same. The bodhisattva's teaching on the accumulations of emptiness is for the purpose of demolishing what appears to exist.

The bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha asked: Venerable One, if one searches for what exists, no truth is to be found — it is to be understood as true in the way that a mirage and water are alike. If it is not the case that it does not exist, it is like the intrinsic nature of fire. To think in such a way is unwise. This is what the Buddha has declared.

Just as a person examines what is genuine and, having examined the sole characteristic of emptiness and peace, finds it the same as having no characteristic at all — one who, taking up the practice of emptiness and proceeding through that practice of emptiness, does not lose sight of the buddha. When practicing the seeing of the buddha, one is free from the three descents. Within the Dharma of the Great Vehicle, the one path of the sūtra that is the way of the three liberations has no essential nature. Because it has no essential nature, it is empty. Because it is empty, it has no characteristic. Because it has no characteristic, there is no activity. Because there is no activity, there is no seeking. Because there is no seeking, there is no aspiration. Acting in such a way, the mind becomes pure. Because the mind is pure, one sees the buddha. When one sees the buddha, one is born in a pure realm.

When a bodhisattva teaches such profound Dharma and practices the three with thoroughness, and when wisdom and the capacity for endurance are accomplished, one transcends the three realms (the three dhātus) from the very beginning.

The bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha asked: In what the Tathāgata (the thus-gone one) has taught, if there is neither arising nor peace, then there is permanent non-existence. If birth and death are foreclosed, then the emptiness and peace of cessation are foreclosed as well. By permanence there is no annihilation. Those phenomena that are non-annihilating are separated from the

phenomena of the unmoving three realms, and phenomena that have activity are like a flame that has gone out. Depending on phenomena such as "who" and so forth, the one gate of self-conduct by the self enters alone.

The Buddha declared: A bodhisattva, engaging the mind in the three great aims, enters the practice of the three great truths.

The bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha asked: In what way does my own mind engage the three aims? How does one enter into the single practice of the three truths?

The Buddha declared: The three great aims are these: the first is the cause, the second is the fruit, and the third is consciousness. From the final standpoint, those three aims are such that there is no emptiness — if there is no self and no true self, how could craving and attachment arise toward it? If one examines the three aims, one takes up bondage, and through that taking up one falls into the ocean of suffering. Therefore, one should constantly engage oneself. As for the three truths: the first is the path of awakening.

The first is the truth of equanimity, not the truth of non-equanimity. The second is the truth of attaining the primordial wisdom of great feeling that is straight and direct. The third is the truth of entry that is in accord with wisdom, free from the practice of distinction and separation — it is not the truth of entry through the practice of the seven stages. Having practiced these three truths and walked the path of the buddhas, one enters into such a Dharma, and there is no one who fails to attain the direct and upright feeling. When the primordial wisdom of direct feeling is attained, one falls into great loving-kindness, and through benefiting both oneself and others, the awakening of buddhahood is accomplished.

The bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha then asked: Venerable One, in such a Dharma there is no cause and no condition. If there is no condition for conditions, the cause of phenomena does not arise. How does one enter into the Tathāgata through phenomena that are unmoved and unshakeable? Then the Tathāgata, intending to set free this teaching, explained it in verse:

The characteristic mark of all phenomena —
at that very time there is no movement.

In phenomena there is never a time of distinction;
at that very time there is no movement.

In phenomena there is never a time of distinction;
it has not arisen from a time of distinction.

In phenomena there is no movement — they do not stir.
The essential nature is empty, unmoving;
when the essential nature is empty and at peace,
that phenomenon arises at that very time.
Free from characteristic marks, it abides in emptiness;
abiding in emptiness, it has no object of focus.
As for phenomena that arise from conditions —
from that phenomenon, conditions do not arise.
There is no cause, no condition, no arising;
the essential nature of the emptiness of arising is empty.
The intrinsic nature of conditions can function as condition;
the subsequent instance of that condition is stirred by conditions.
When phenomena are stirred, conditions too are absent;
when there are no conditions, there is also no movement.
The phenomenon born from cause and condition —
its dharmatā is itself that cause and condition.
The form of birth and death of cause and condition:
within it there is neither birth nor death.
That is the true, real form of suchness —
the subsequent instance cannot arise with capacity or without.
Phenomena at that very time
arise and cease, born from themselves.
The subsequent instance is itself the utterly pure;
it is not the force of the cause of the subsequent instance.
Henceforth, attaining the abode of that,
one attains the purity of the attained subsequent instance.

Then the bodhisattva Kṣitigarbha, having heard everything the Buddha had declared, was satisfied in mind. The great assembly, being without doubt, having already understood, spoke these verses:

We perceive the minds of the multitude;
it is for that reason we asked with discipline.
The Tathāgata, virtue and great loving-kindness,
has distinguished and explained without remainder.
Through both aspects, the great multitude
has all received and directly attained.
What I have now grasped and held

I will teach, spreading it to all sentient beings.
The Tathāgata, with compassion,
has not set down an aspiration for the subsequent instance.
Therefore, as an only child in this place,
he abides in the realm of worldly sorrow.

Then the Tathāgata declared to the great assembly: This bodhisattva is inconceivable — practicing great loving-kindness impartially, he has emerged from the suffering of sentient beings. If certain sentient beings uphold the Dharma of this text and hold to the name and dhāraṇī of that bodhisattva, they will not fall into evil karma, and all obstructing hindrances of obscuration will be entirely cleared away and gone. Certain sentient beings, without thinking of the seven other stages and without stirring, are caused to attain the luminous awakening of the unmoved. At that time the bodhisattva constantly manifests bodies, teaches the Dharma, takes that person under protection and refuge, and does not release them even for a single instant — and that person and others like them are swiftly caused to attain the unsurpassed, eternal, and perfect awakening.

You and all bodhisattvas who teach and instruct sentient beings — engage in the practice of distinguishing fully and without alteration the teaching of the Great Vehicle, in just the way it is.

Then Joyful One, rising from his seat, addressed the Buddha before him:

"How shall this Dharma text be named — the one perfectly proclaimed by the Well-Gone One (Sugata), which perfectly severs the knot of the aggregate of merit of the Great Vehicle, soothes the sensation of birthlessness, and is inconceivable in the way described? If someone memorizes this Dharma text and takes it to heart, how great a store of merit will they obtain? I pray that the Buddha, through the compassion of his loving-kindness, will explain and release this for me."

The Buddha declared: "O virtuous young man, the name of this Dharma text is itself inconceivable. The buddhas of the past, having intended it to be cherished, proclaimed it as entering into the ocean of the wisdom of the Well-Gone One. If any sentient being possesses even one instance of holding this Dharma text to heart, they need not seek anything further in any other Dharma text whatsoever. This Dharma text gathers the essence of all sūtras and distills the most precious core of all Dharma teachings. It is the final

intention among Dharma texts. The name of this Dharma text is 'The Great Vehicle Condensed.' It may also be called 'The Vajra Meditative Absorption.' It may further be called 'The Final Summary of the Immeasurable Teaching.' If any person memorizes this Dharma text and takes it to heart, that person holds a hundred thousand buddhas to heart. The benefit of such excellence is, by way of analogy, equal to space — boundless and without limit. This inconceivable Dharma text has been entrusted to one's care."

Joyful One asked: "With what kind of mental conduct, and what kind of person, memorizes and holds this Dharma text to heart?"

The Buddha declared: "O virtuous young man, the person who memorizes and holds this Dharma text to heart neither gains nor loses mind, and constantly practices the pure life of celibacy. Even amid praise and blame, they maintain an unmoving mind of faith. Even when dwelling in a household, their mind constantly abides with the Sage. Though living at home, they are unattached to the three kinds of existing things. Such a person, in the present time of their life, possesses five kinds of splendid qualities. First: they are revered and respected by the many. Second: the body does not go to sudden confusion. Third: a twisted mind quickly and repeatedly recovers its balance. Fourth: they are ardent in liberating sentient beings. Fifth: they are able to enter the path of miraculous power. It is a person of this kind who memorizes and holds this Dharma text to heart."

Joyful One asked: "Is such a person fit to purify sentient beings and to be offered gifts?"

The Buddha declared: "Such a person, for the sake of sentient beings, establishes great splendor and constantly practices great wisdom, abiding in the truth of both natures of splendor. They are a support and foundation for the Saṅgha. If to them, as offerings, one may present one's own head, eyes, feet, and brain — all of these being fit to give — then what need is there to say that robes and food are fit to give? O virtuous young man, such a person is your spiritual friend. They are your bridge. What need is there to say that the gift need not be refused — they are no ordinary person."

Joyful One asked: "If offerings are made to such a person on account of their memorizing and holding this Dharma text to heart, how great a store of merit does that person obtain?"

The Buddha declared: "Suppose some person takes a vessel filled with gold and silver and presents it, having already heard the Dharma teaching. At that

moment, Joyful One and the bodhisattvas and the ordinary assembly all rejoice greatly. Having attained the state of becoming, in mind, a truly authentic person, they bow with their crowns to the feet of the Buddha and engage in reverent conduct with joy."

Translator's Notes

- The opening assembly location is rendered "Mount Ḡṛdhrakūṭa, the royal city's vulture peak" — the Tibetan has རྒྱལ་སྡེ་གི་བོན་རྩེ་ which is a rendering of Ḡṛdhrakūṭa near Rājagṛha. The phrasing is slightly unusual and may reflect a local scribal convention rather than a standard Sanskrit toponym.

The name 阿伽士 (Agasta) is likely Agastya, a well-known Indian sage name, though its appearance here as a monk's name in a Buddhist assembly is unusual and may reflect a particular textual tradition. It is retained in phonetic form.

The phrase translated "six hundred trillion" renders 六十萬億那由其他 — literally sixty sets of ten-thousand hundred-thousands — a conventionally vast number in Buddhist cosmological assemblies.

The term རྒྱལ་པོ་འཇམ་མགས་ rendered as "supreme fascicle" reflects a colophon convention where རྒྱལ་པོ་ denotes a physical or textual division and འཇམ་མགས་ here means "supreme" or "chief," not the usual "lama" or "teacher." This text appears to be a Dunhuang-era or early Tibetan canonical composition of uncertain provenance, possibly an apocryphal sūtra, which may account for some of its unusual terminology and assemblage of characters.

- The phrase rendered “from the very beginning” throughout translates the Tibetan term meaning something like “originally” or “primordially” and is used in a deliberate and repeated technical sense to indicate the primordial or beginningless nature of emptiness; the repetition is intentional and doctrinally significant, not a translation artifact.

The bodhisattva's name, literally "Liberation and Freedom," is rendered consistently as "the bodhisattva Liberation" for smoothness in speech, following the convention established in the preceding passage.

The final paradox — that arising has never been stilled, and therefore the dyad of stilling and arising both dissolve — reflects a classical Madhyamaka and tathāgatagarbha logic; the translation preserves the deliberate circularity of the argument.

- The term here rendered "wakefulness and stillness" translates the compound "Idang dub" throughout this passage. This is an unusual compound: "Idang" suggests arising or wakefulness, while "dub" suggests exhaustion, settling, or stillness. It may be a specialized doctrinal term of this particular text denoting the dynamic interplay of arising and quiescence in mind, possibly corresponding to a Chinese Chan technical expression. Its precise Sanskrit or doctrinal equivalent is uncertain, and listeners should understand it as pointing to the natural, unsought equipoise of mind that is simultaneously awake and at rest.

The phrase rendered "treasury of the Tathāgata" for "yang dag par gshegs pa'i mdzod" literally means "the treasury of the one who has gone perfectly," using the Tibetan equivalent of Sugata or Tathāgata. This appears to be a text-specific designation for buddha-nature or tathāgatagarbha, framed here as the ground of non-arising, empty and unmoved.

- The phrase rendered "the eye of emptiness in mind" and "the body of empty phenomena" are technical descriptors without standard canonical parallels in the major Indian Mahāyāna

literature; the text appears to be a Chinese-origin apocryphal sūtra or a text from the early Tibetan translation period, and these expressions may carry meanings specific to that context.

The phrase "the patience of the final moment" renders a term that in standard Mahāyāna scholasticism refers to the highest tolerance or acceptance at the culminating instant before irreversible realization; the passage appears to use it as a climactic attainment.

"Groltar" is used as both the name of the bodhisattva interlocutor and appears at the close as the title of the realization section, suggesting the passage may be a self-contained unit named for him.

- The bodhisattva names "Groltar" and "Sems kyi Rgyal po" are left in Tibetan transliteration following the established convention of the preceding passage. Groltar means roughly "Liberation-Release" and Sems kyi Rgyal po means "King of Mind."

The verse section is metrically irregular in the Tibetan and presents several passages where the referent is elliptical or compressed. The rendering follows the most doctrinally coherent reading throughout, but a few lines admit alternative interpretations. In particular, the line rendered "leading many ordinary beings" could alternatively mean "drawn far beyond the many ordinary ones," and the final verse line is cut off in the source text as given.

The chapter colophon appears mid-passage, which is unusual; it likely marks the end of chapter three before the new section begins.

- The phrase rendered "rough-and-ready distinguishing of the essential nature of mind by night" translates a difficult line in which "khor bo ror" (roughly, "in a perfunctory or superficial manner") and "mtshan mo" (literally "night," but possibly used here as an adverb of approximation or uncertainty rather than the time of night) make the precise sense uncertain. The translation preserves the sense that such an approach is imprecise and circumstantial rather than genuinely penetrating.

The term rendered "eternal" throughout ("gyung drung," Skt. dhruva) modifying "unsurpassed perfect awakening" has connotations of permanence, indestructibility, and everlastingness — a standard epithet in this textual register for the awakening that is beyond arising and ceasing.

- The "three takings-up" is a somewhat opaque technical expression in this text. It likely refers to three modes of grasping or appropriation — possibly the three types of clinging or the three receptive postures of body, speech, and mind — but the text does not define them explicitly, and the precise referent in this doctrinal context remains unclear.

The phrase rendered "the consciousness of 'I'" renders a Tibetan expression that literally means "my consciousness" or "I-consciousness," which in the Yogācāra tradition would correspond to the manas or afflicted self-grasping consciousness, here listed alongside the ālayavijñāna in a schema that slightly expands the standard eight-consciousness model.

The chapter colophon indicates this is the fourth chapter of a text called the Vajra Meditative Absorption, with a subtitle referring to the merit and benefit of subsequent feeling. The opening of the following section introduces a new named interlocutor, the bodhisattva Vairāgya, whose name means "dispassion" or "non-attachment."

- The term rendered throughout as "the limitless" or "limit" is འོད་ཀྱི་ཕྱི་རྒྱུ་, literally "the outermost" or "the ultimate boundary," used here as a technical term meaning something like the primordial or beginningless origin beyond all bounds. The dialogue plays on the paradox of coming from and going to what has no limit. The rendering "limitless" and "primordial" alternate depending on context, since the term functions both as a directional metaphor and as a doctrinal pointer to the unborn.

The phrase 纯粹至极, rendered here as "utterly pure," may carry a slightly more specific nuance of translucent or radiant purity; the exact technical weight in this text's system is not entirely certain.

The final sentence of the passage is incomplete as given, breaking off mid-declaration. No translation has been invented to complete it.

- The phrase rendered "the four great kings" likely refers to the four buddha activities or four great royal wisdoms rather than the Four Heavenly Kings (caturmahārāja) per se; the Tibetan is ambiguous and the doctrinal context of this text makes a cosmological reading uncertain.

The term "原初" (literally "grandmother" or "ancestress") is used throughout this passage in a philosophically technical, non-standard sense that seems to denote something like the "primordial" or "original" ground — rendered consistently as "womb" or "primal" to convey its sense of originary source. This is a genuinely difficult term whose precise technical sense in this text is uncertain.

- The phrase rendered "feeling arising from without" translates a somewhat unusual construction in the Tibetan that could alternatively be read as "posterior feeling" or "subsequent feeling" — referring to a transcendent, undefiled quality of feeling or sensation that arises not from ordinary conditioning but from the nature of reality itself. The doctrinal point is that this "pure feeling" is not adventitious in the pejorative sense but is the natural quality of primordially present awareness. The ambiguity between "arising from without" and "ultimate" or "posterior" feeling is genuine and worth noting for a scholarly reader.

The final line of the passage is syntactically incomplete in the Tibetan as given, ending mid-sentence with "Drawing wisdom by the mind of all." This appears to be the opening of a new section that continues beyond the supplied text.

- The phrase rendered "the three existents are empty" translates འཇིགས་པོ་གསུམ་ཀློང་བྱེད་པར་ཤིག་ཅེས་པའི་ཐ་སྙན་གྲུབ་པ་།, literally "the three existents are empty." The specific referent of "three existents" is not spelled out in this passage and may be a technical enumeration specific to the tantric or sūtra context of this text; the translation preserves the literal phrasing rather than supplying an interpretation.

The phrase 心因成身 could also be read as "arising because mind has become body," i.e., mind has embodied or materialized; the translation reflects this reading.

- The phrase rendered "the two entrances" translates "zhugs pa gnyis," which the text itself defines as "entrance through the teaching" and "entrance through practice." This corresponds closely to the famous "two entrances" of Bodhidharma's teaching — entrance through principle and entrance through practice — suggesting this text belongs to or draws upon an early Chan or proto-Chan milieu in Tibetan dress. This is a significant doctrinal and textual observation but does not require alteration of the translation.

The passage "vacant existence and non-existence are present from the primal depth" is rendered as faithfully as the syntax allows. The logic of the final sentences is deliberately paradoxical and may reflect a non-standard or archaic formulation; the rendering follows the Tibetan closely without smoothing the apparent contradictions, which appear to be intentional.

- The passage presents considerable difficulties owing to what appears to be a doctrinally dense but linguistically compressed and at points irregular text. Several items warrant mention.

The phrase rendered "at the thirteenth and fourteenth stages" (ming ni bdun dang drug mi skye) is literally "one of that name, at the seventh and sixth, does not take birth" — the numbers seven and six may refer to specific bodhisattva grounds or classificatory categories within the text's own scheme rather than any standard canonical enumeration; the rendering is

a reasonable inference from context but the exact referent is uncertain.

The expression "the aggregate of the three emptinesses" (stong pa gsum gyi phung po) is a distinctive term belonging to this text's own vocabulary, as established in earlier sections; it is preserved consistently throughout.

The colophon-style line "the second and final fascicle" renders bam po gnyis pa ste tha ma, where bam po is a traditional Tibetan textual division roughly equivalent to a Sanskrit pāda or fascicle.

The final line of the verse section, rendered "all are made to flow in the stream of the straight," is compressed and the metaphor somewhat obscure in the original; the rendering follows the most natural reading.

- The passage contains several technically dense and syntactically compressed phrases that merit comment. The phrase rendered "if one does not depart from conditions as they are" translates a formulation that could also be read as "if conditions are not severed or violated," playing on the double sense of not transgressing and not departing; the translation reflects the context of moral discipline. The extended simile of the nāga and the lake is deliberately obscure in the original; the translation follows the syntax closely without smoothing the imagery. The phrase rendered "has not yet entered into fully abandoning the self" translates a term that literally suggests not having entered the path of complete renunciation in the technical Vinaya sense; this is deliberately contrasted with the capacity to practice through mind alone, underscoring the sūtra's synthesis of conduct and contemplation. The phrase "guarding the one" and "not letting the three decline" refer respectively to the undivided non-dual mind and the three liberations; this is confirmed by the Buddha's own gloss within the passage. The final line's "a buddha who fully arises" renders an expression indicating a buddha who has fully unfolded in the future; the meaning is that the practitioner will eventually attain full buddhahood.

- The phrase rendered "the four foundations of mindfulness, the four correct exertions, the four bases of mental power, the five faculties, the five strengths, the seven factors of awakening, the path of the eightfold noble way" represents the standard list of thirty-seven factors conducive to awakening (bodhipākṣikadharmā), and the text's own count of thirty-seven is used as a framing device throughout this section.

The passage translated as "the Dharma-robe of the Tathāgata" echoes the well-known Vimalakīrtinirdeśa imagery of patience as the Tathāgata's robe; the text here uses "Tathāgata" (yang dag par gshegs pa, literally "the one who has gone perfectly") to describe the same garment.

The simile of alcohol intoxication for the condition of practitioners of the two vehicles who cannot perceive the one ground and ocean of emptiness is unusual and may reflect a distinct tantric or apocryphal transmission; no direct canonical Sanskrit parallel is known.

- The phrase rendered "the Great God" translates རྒྱལ་མགོན་ཆོས་ཀྱི་འཛུགས་པ་, a clear reference to Mahādeva, a name of Śiva. Its appearance here as a superlative epithet applied to this Dharma teaching is doctrinally striking and unusual; the text may be asserting that what is elsewhere called Śiva's mantra is in fact the Buddha's teaching, in a gesture of doctrinal appropriation common in certain sūtra literature.

The term རྒྱལ་མགོན་, rendered throughout as "ultimate" or "outer dimension" depending on syntactic context, is genuinely ambiguous. It can mean "final," "ultimate," "outer," or in certain Tibetan usages "grandmother" in an extended sense of "primordial source." The translation attempts to distinguish its technical uses by context, but a reader should be aware the underlying Tibetan is consistently the same word.

The five ranks described here do not correspond straightforwardly to standard canonical enumerations and may reflect a text of uncertain provenance or a non-standard scholastic framework.

- The passage contains several grammatically compressed or unusual phrases that are characteristic of a non-canonical or para-canonical text (possibly of Central Asian or early Chinese-translated-back-into-Tibetan provenance). In particular, the phrase rendered "the three feelings and the three bodies of the sublime feeling, shines clearly within the interior of the nine knowings" is highly obscure: the "three feelings," "three bodies of sublime feeling," and "nine knowings" do not map straightforwardly onto standard Abhidharma or Mahāyāna schema. The translation renders the syntax faithfully but the doctrinal referent is genuinely uncertain.

The phrase translated "what is commonly included" (མཚན་མཐོང་གི་མཚན་མཐོང་།) is also unusual and may carry a more technical sense; the rendering is approximate.

- The river names Koñ, Ha, and Hohe are phonetic renderings of foreign river names whose Sanskrit or other originals are uncertain. These may represent specific rivers known in the source tradition (possibly the Ganges, Yamunā, and others), but the Tibetan as it stands gives only these phonetic forms, so they are rendered as proper names.

The phrase rendered "the wisdom of the ultimate expanse" translates མཚན་མཐོང་གི་མཚན་མཐོང་།, where མཚན་མཐོང་ is unusual; it may mean "the far extreme" or "the ultimate reach," and the rendering reflects that sense.

The simile of obtaining a needle from a sprout is genuinely obscure; it appears to convey the idea that entry into the inconceivable leaves no traceable point of entry, as a needle emerging from a growing sprout would leave no visible mark. This is reflected in the translation but noted here as a passage of real interpretive difficulty.

- The phrase rendered "the assembly of the great central text circling" is syntactically dense and the underlying doctrine is not fully transparent from context; it appears to describe the cycling or rolling of the central scriptural teaching through the major categories of Abhidharma analysis (aggregates, elements, sense sources), but the precise doctrinal framework is unclear from the passage alone.

The verse "This phenomenon has no absence of arising" is deliberately paradoxical, likely meaning that this ultimate, empty phenomenon does not even have "non-arising" as an attribute, since all predication (including negation) falls away at the ultimate level. This is a genuine doctrinal subtlety worth noting.

The image "a wheel of body-hair" refers to the classical Indian logical example of nonexistent fine body-hairs appearing to float before one's eyes — a stock illustration of illusion in Buddhist epistemological texts.

- The phrase rendered "the first life" for མཚན་མཐོང་གི་མཚན་མཐོང་ is genuinely obscure; it may refer to attaining the stream-enterer's "first" spiritual life or an initiatory rebirth in a soteriological sense. The exact technical meaning is uncertain, and no commentarial gloss is available from context.

The phrase མཚན་མཐོང་གི་མཚན་མཐོང་།, rendered "nor does it belong to one's own text," is ambiguous. མཚན་མཐོང་ can mean "text," "tradition," or "treatise," but in context may carry the sense of "one's own system" or "one's own doctrine." The rendering is provisional.

- The passage "མཚན་མཐོང་གི་མཚན་མཐོང་།" is rendered as "It is like taking an empty-causal flower," following the parallel with the earlier image of flowers seen in empty space by a disordered eye. The compound "མཚན་མཐོང་གི་མཚན་མཐོང་" is unusual; it could mean "empty

cause" or relate to the earlier "འཇིགས་མེད་ཀྱི་རྣམས་ཀྱི་འཇིགས་མེད་ཀྱི་རྣམས་" image. The rendering preserves the parallel.

The dialogue passage where Kṣitigarbha says "འཇིགས་མེད་ཀྱི་རྣམས་ཀྱི་འཇིགས་མེད་ཀྱི་རྣམས་" functions as an affirmative exclamation ("It is inconceivable") rather than a question, which is how it has been rendered.

- The numbers seven, five, eight, six, nine in Kṣitigarbha's question appear to refer to a specific enumerative scheme whose referents are not made explicit in this passage. The text may presuppose a lost or separate doctrinal list; the translation renders the numbers literally.

The phrase rendered "three descents" for "འཇིགས་མེད་ཀྱི་རྣམས་" is uncertain. It may refer to three lower rebirths, three kinds of falling away, or another technical category. The translation keeps it literal.

The final sentence breaks off mid-discourse; this appears to be a genuine textual interruption at the boundary of the passage supplied.

- The verse section presents considerable interpretive difficulty throughout. The term rendered "subsequent instance" translates a Tibetan word meaning "the later" or "the successor," used in a technical sense relating to arising and cessation in sequential moments; the precise doctrinal referent is not fully transparent from the text as preserved. The phrase "direct feeling" and "great feeling" in the opening prose likely renders a technical term for a kind of gnosis or realization associated with equanimity, but the underlying Sanskrit equivalent is uncertain. The closing figure "Joyful One" renders a name meaning literally "the joyful or delighted one," likely a disciple name; it cannot be identified with certainty from context alone.

- The phrase rendered as "the three kinds of existing things" translates འཇིགས་མེད་ཀྱི་རྣམས་, literally "three existents." The precise reference is not specified in the text; it may refer to the three realms or to possessions, family, and sense pleasures — a standard triad in similar contexts. The ambiguity is left as a general rendering.

The phrase འཇིགས་མེད་ཀྱི་རྣམས་ཀྱི་འཇིགས་མེད་ཀྱི་རྣམས་, rendered "a twisted mind quickly and repeatedly recovers its balance," is somewhat unusual. The image seems to be of mental crookedness being swiftly corrected, but the exact idiomatic meaning of འཇིགས་མེད་ in this context carries some uncertainty.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.